To the Airport

By Julianne Bernstein

INTRODUCTION

TED: Try therapy.
MARCIA: You shouldn't have to pay someone to listen to you.
TED: What about friends?
MARCIA: They're too involved in the situation.
TED: boyfriend?
MARCIA: He IS the situation.
TED: Pick a random person.
MARICA: Like who?
TED: Like a cab driver.
BOTH: "To the Airport"
TED: By Julianne Bernstein

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(TED sits in his taxicab. He is parked and waiting. He beeps the horn, which sounds twice. He pulls out a postcard from his shirt pocket, reads it, smiles and puts it back. He beeps the horn again. He looks at his clipboard. confirms the address, gets out, goes around the cab and looks up. He gets back in the taxicab. He switches from "park" to "drive" when the sound of a large heavy door slamming and a woman 50 voice is heard.)

WOMAN'S VOICE: You bastard! I don't care if you stay and rot! Along with the Chinese take-out you took out last Friday! Don't you follow me! I don't want to see your face! *(It is MARCIA. She enters with several large suitcases. She throws them down on the ground and speaks Upstage Right, as if she :s yelling to the sixth floor of a high-rise.)* Don't follow me! You hear me?! *(TED honks the horn.)*

MARCIA: *(To TED)* Yeah, yeah. I'm comin'.

TED: If this isn't a good time, I could come back later.

MARCIA: And what am I gonna do with you *later?* Kennedy Airport. *Now!*

TED: You sure you wanna get in this cab? In your state of mind? ,

MARCIA: If you're here to make my life miserable, you can take a number. *(Pause)* Bobby?! Hey, Bobby, do you hear me?!

TED: *(Pause)* I can't believe he don't hear ya.

MARCIA: *(To TED)* Shut off that damn engine. Shut it off!

TED: I got the meter goin'.

MARCIA: For what? You're charging me to stand on the curb? Did you hear me? I said shut if off! *(He does so.)* I'm tired of it! Five years I'm with you, what do I get? *No* ring. *No* promise, even. I'm tellin' you. A dishwasher is no real sign of love. No, sir. You can't even say it. "Marriage," Bobby. The word is "marriage." I can see it now. My fortieth birthday. My fiftieth. And still no ring. You'll bring me another sweet, forget-me-not appliance, you will. *(Pause)* A little gold won't kill you, Bobby. A little gold won't break you!

TED: Excuse me, but

MARCIA: *(To TED)* What? What?!

TED: Two-thirty-five West 41st? Sixth floor? Is that who you're talkin' to? The sixth floor?

MARCIA: No, I got a special problem with my neck, and I'm talking to the couple in the basement. Come on. The bags. They're growing mold out here. *(TED gets out; he loads the baggage in the trunk. MARCIA looking up)* And don't call. You better not call. I'm changing my name. The long distance operator'll laugh in your face. "Who?" "Marcia who?" they'll ask. "Who the hell you talkin' about?" "There's no ..." Aha! You thought I'd say it... my name. My

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new name. Well, forget it! *(TED is finished loading the suitcases. He walks up to her and opens her door.)* What's this? Limo service? I'll open my own door, thank you. *(She gets in and slides to the left. TED is about to shut the door.)* I'll shut my own door. Double thank you! *(Leaving the door open, he steps around to the front, and gets into the driver seat. MARCIA slides back to the right to shut the door, but instead, gets out again.)* I'm shutting this door, Bobby. I got my hand on the handle and I'm closin' it shut! Do you hear me?! *(Pause)* Do you get what I'm sayin'?!

TED: Lady, I got a life, too, you know!

MARCIA: *(Quickly moving into the cab, and "threatening him at gunpoint")* Go ahead. Start the meter. I dare you. *(Calling out the window)* I'm leavin' now, Bobby? Bobby, you hear me? You can start cryin'. Shed those buckets, Bucko! Cry! Cry! Cry! *(She slams the door shut, sits still, and listens. After a beat)* Turn the key. *(Pause)* Turn the key, I said. *(He does. Sound of the engine is heard.)* Hear that, Bobby? *(She slides to the middle of the seat.)* Go. *(Pause)* Drive. *(He switches gears, checks his mirror and drives.)*

TED: Boy, he sure did a number on you. At least he didn't throw you and your Wandering Jew out on the pavement!

MARCIA: What?!

TED: I had a pick-up in Queens just last night. This nice lookin' guy. He had real good skin. Sittin' there with a pillowcase full of clothes and his favorite Wandering Jew wandering all over the street. He didn't know what to do. The roots were torn to pieces - all the leaves were flyin' towards Flatbush.

MARCIA: So? What do you want? *A medal* for pickin' him up? *A prize* for doin' your job? All you guys - you want medals, trophies for just gettin' up in the

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mornin'! *(Pause)* Just get me out of here. I wanna go - go where no *man* has gone before.

TED: Yeah? Where's that? You goin' overseas?

MARCIA: Yeah. Overseas. Way overseas.

TED: Yeah? Wow. Can you believe I got no postcards from overseas? Plenty of domestics, but not a single card from overseas.

MARCIA: What the hell are you talkin' about? *(He pulls out his card; he hands it to her.)* What am I supposed to do with this?

TED: Write me. I'll write you back.

MARCIA: Excuse me?

TED: But I gotta have your address. Your zip code.

MARCIA: That's ridiculous. That's illegal.

TED: Hey, there's no way it'll work without the zip. It'll get lost and chewed up by those U.S. Postal pigs. It's gotta have a zip. You got mine. Now gimme yours. I'll write you.

MARCIA: What? Like a letter?

TED: Or a card if that's your pleasure.

MARCIA: What the hell for?

TED: Hey, it sounds like you could use your own personal Abby.

MARCIA: Who?

TED: Abby. Dear Abby. Come on. What's your zip? Gimme your zip.

MARCIA: You're crazy. I'll give you that. You're a loonie. I'll give you that much. *(Pause)* Now, be quiet. I got so much stuff tyin' up my brain right now. I wish I were dead. Yeah. Pretend I'm dead. Pretend you're driving a hearse. *(Silence. To herself)* He don't understand. He don't listen to me. That's the

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problem. He don't listen. He don't hear. I don't care about gettin' married. I mean, I'd like it and all. But I love him. I tell him that. But he don't believe me. I just want him to believe me. To hear me. *(Bitingly)* Well?

TED: Well, what?

MARCIA: You hear me? Are you deaf as well?

TED: No. I heard.

MARCIA: Yeah, what'd I say? Tell me what I said.

TED: You said: He don't understand. That, like, he don't listen to you. That *that's* the problem. That, like, he don't listen. That he don't hear. That you don't care about like gettin' married. You'd like, like it and all, but that you love him. And you tell him that. But like he don't believe you. That you just want him to believe you. To hear you. *(Pause)* Well?

MARCIA: *(Pause)* Right. You got it. Word for word. Like you got the back seat bugged.

TED: You know the best thing? Gettin' cards from places I dream about. I mean, I had a pick-up on Times Square 'bout a year ago, and guess where he was from? Guess.

MARCIA: I don't know. Paris?

TED: Kansas. I pick him up in the middle of Times Square, right under the Sony sign. Another real nice guy. Though his skin wasn't as clear. But we got to talkin'. Turns out he came to New York City to be somethin'. I don't know what. He didn't know what. It didn't work out. So we struck up a correspondence, and now I get cards from Kansas. Corn country and all that. I got Kansas all over my kitchen. How about it? All I need is the zip on two-thirty-five West

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MARCIA: I'm leavin'. That's not my zip code anymore. I'm leavin'. Get it? I'm leavin'. *(Silence)*

TED: How come?

MARCIA: I don't know.

TED: Me, neither. I mean here and now. I don't know. But via the U.S. mail, I usually got this figured by now. Now, I'm aware of the rising cost of postage these days; I can't help that - but my advice will always be first-rate.

MARCIA: You know. That's all I ever wanted from him. Was his first-rate effort. I mean, I know he's gettin' old. Me, too. We're not runnin' naked through the living room to get to the Jiffy Pop popcorn anymore. It's just what happens after so many years. And sex is ... well ... it is what it is.

TED: It is?

MARCIA: It is.

TED: Sounds like you're going through maybe a mid-life thing.

MARCIA: Me? Mid-life? What kind of a thing is that to say? That's supposed to *help* me? Give me direction? A confirmation that I'm having a mid-life thing?

TED: I told you I'm no good in person, face-to-face. One on one. Ah, but on a postcard or sealed up in a letter? Pure gold. Believe me. Really. This one guy was writin' me all the way from Delaware. You know, the valley? He was having a hell of a time with his teenage daughter. She wanted to run away to Soho with her boyfriend and open up a store selling *his* oil paintings of traffic in Ohio and other suburbs, and *her* bracelets made out of gum wrappers and little wet rocks.

MARCIA: Wrappers and rocks? What'd you tell the father?

TED: A bunch of stuff. I mean, it was pourin' out of me. Like I was writin' fortune

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cookies or horoscopes. Like I was talkin' right out of the Ten Commandments.

MARCIA: So? What'd you tell him?

TED: After six pounds of stationery, I tell him to get off his tucas and go to the grand opening of his kid's store. I say to him, "Your own children will show you the way." That's what I wrote. Their little shop's on Bleeker Street, right next to the Lebanese Deli. It's very popular.

MARCIA: But the father. He was against it.

TED: Not after he saw what a good business they were doin'. He sent me a picture of his daughter. Oh, what a doll. A lovely shot of her workin' behind the counter. Dressed real responsible and all. A skirt with a blouse and a bow. Quite a lady, you know? *(Silence)*

MARCIA: Uh-oh.

TED: What?

MARCIA: Just follow the road. Terminal A.

TED: Yeah. Quick. Gimme your zip code. We'll get a correspondence goin'.

MARCIA: It's no good anymore.

TED: Come on. Just write me and tell me how you're doin'. I'll interpret what I read, and tell you what I think.

MARCIA: No! You're not gettin' my code. It's my code. Mine.

TED: *(Pause)* You need me to write you.

MARCIA: You don't know what I need.

TED: Yeah, I do.

MARCIA: Then tell me. Tell me. Tell me everything you know and make me see it in a different way. Make me see him in a different way.

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TED: Whoa. You just can't order up advice like... like ... it's a pastrami sandwich or something. I need time to think ...time to ...

MARCIA: What? What?

TED: Let me have my card.

MARCIA: But I thought you

TED: I'll give it back. I'll give it right back. *(TED takes a pen from his shirt pocket, and the card which MARCIA hands him. He scribbles a note on the back of the card.)*

MARCIA: Hey, don't write while you're drivin'.

TED: I've been driving for fifteen years. I can put up a house of cards while I'm driving.

MARCIA: If we have even a little fender bender - you're dead, buddy.

TED: Be quiet. This is it. This is what you been waitin' for.

MARCIA: Just shut up and take the red arrow. No, the blue. Yeah, the blue ...

TED: Hang on.

MARCIA: I got a plane to catch. Let's go.

TED: 'What airline?

MARCIA: I'm not sure.

TED: What's your ticket say? Check your ticket.

MARCIA: Ticket?

TED: You don't have a ticket?

MARCIA: Not yet.

TED: You're expectin' to fly overseas with a ticket you bought ten minutes before?

MARCIA: What's wrong with that?

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TED: That's stupid. You know how much you gotta pay?

MARCIA: I got money.

TED: You need a lot if you want a ticket right up front. I mean, unless you buy a year in advance, they'll charge you a thousand dollars just to fly to Detroit.

MARCIA: Nobody's gonna pay that much to go to Detroit.

TED: Hey, if you're stupid enough to fly to Detroit, you deserve to pay that much! *(MARCIA starts weeping.)* Hey, you're not stupid. I didn't mean it.

MARCIA: I get so tired of talkin' to him about it.

TED: You call that *talkin'?* You have to yell like that? He wasn't across the country, he was right there.

MARCIA: He was in the other room. In the bathroom. The shower. With his Walkman over his ears. How else am I going to talk to him?

TED: It sounds like he was checkin' out.

MARCIA: I know what he was doin'.

TED: *(Looking in the rear-view mirror)* Ah, get out of my face.

MARCIA: Hey, all I said was

TED: Not you. I got these Good Humor trucks tailing me.

MARCIA: *(Pause)* I hate talkin' in the bathroom. It makes me uncomfortable. *(He hands her the card. She reads.)* After you take a shower with him, go to the kitchen... and pop up some Jiffy Pop. *(Pause)* Forget the towel. *(Silence. Taking a deep breath)* There. Follow that road right there.

TED: It takes you right out of the airport.

MARCIA: I know.

TED: You gonna be OK?

MARCIA: I'll see. *(Pause)* I don't have a card for me.

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TED: Yeah, I know. I know.

MARCIA: But I got yours. Thanks. *(Pause)* 20331. That's my zip. I don't know how long that'll be it. But that's it. That's my zip. 20331. For now, that is.

TED: *(Smiling) 20331.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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